Graphic Design

# Magazine Cover in Photoshop

Summary Notes

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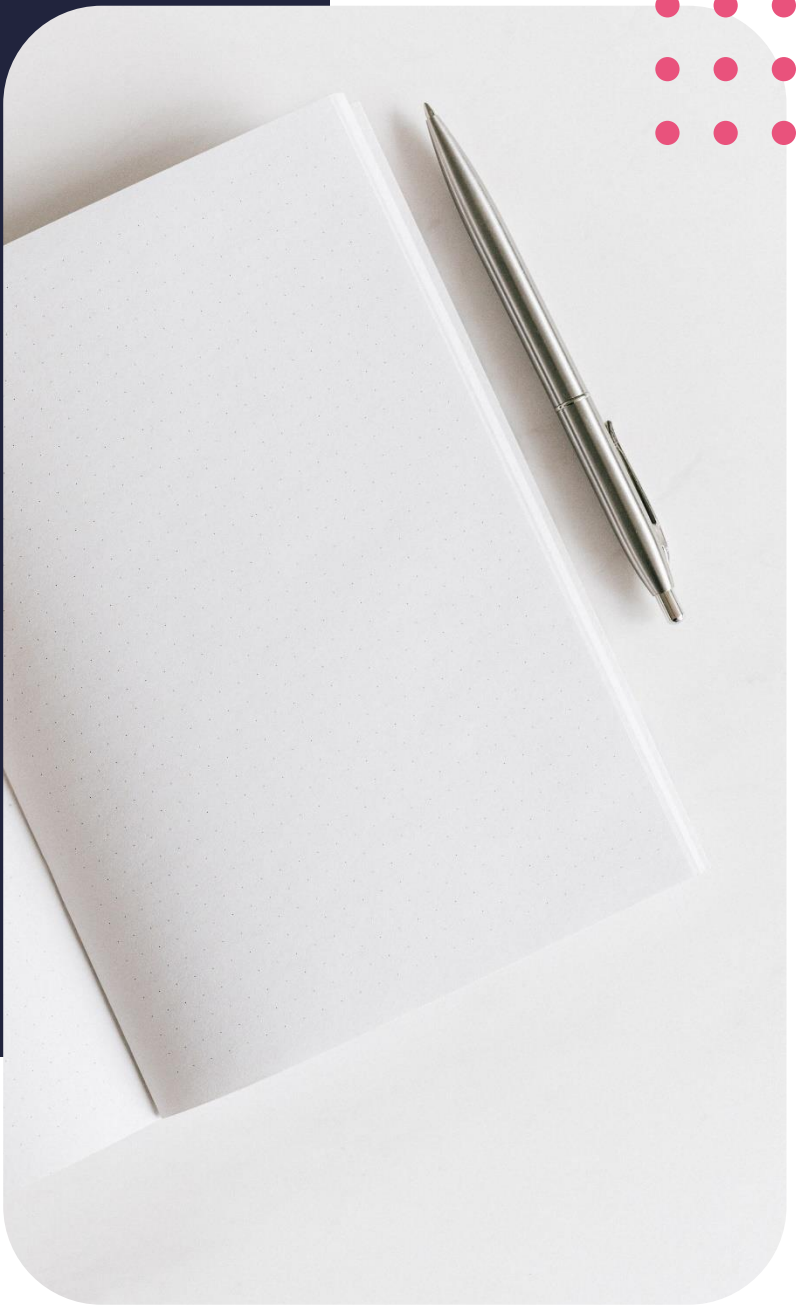


## Lesson outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Lesson outcome 1: Basic photography
- Lesson outcome 2: Magazine cover demo

# Introduction

Let's share an interesting fact. The word magazine originates from the Arabic word "makhazin" which means storehouse and was invented by Englishman Edward Cave in 1731. Before this, magazines were known as periodicals which were basically invented in 1663 by German theologian Johann Rist.

Periodicals came to existence due to the printing press that was invented by Johannes Gutenberg. Suddenly, information was accessible to the masses and this led to the invention of the magazine since people had a hunger for information. This era was also known as the age of enlightenment.

# Basic Photography

Now, as a designer, it comes in handy to have knowledge on other fields as well, examples include web designing, marketing and photography.

As with graphic design, photography is understanding the basics and then simply a matter of practice. With technology nowadays, it is possible to make use of your smart phone camera to take quite decent photographs.

Some tips to give you out of my own experience when it comes to photography are the following:

**The 3 most important factors to consider are: lighting, angle and emotion.**

Having these three factors in your image will immediately create a good image. Also note that when photographing, 1 out of 100 images will probably be excellent. The more experience you have, the better your images will be obviously but that truly amazing photograph that simply stands out above the rest, literally only happens now and again.

Even if you are not interested in photography, it is crucial for graphic designers to understand the basic principles of what makes a photograph exceptional as we are working with photographs daily. You might argue, well, I can simply download a high-quality image from the multitude of stock websites available but simply using an amazing photograph from a stock website leaves you the risk of using something hundreds or even thousands of other designers also have access to.

## Lighting

So, on that note, I would like to leave you with some factors to consider when taking your own photographs. Considering that you will use your smartphone to take a picture, please don't use the flash. Lighting is one of the 3 important factors and I would suggest to rather use natural light. Indoors are quite easy in that you can use window light, which is one of my favourite light sources to make use of.

If you need to photograph outdoors and don't have all the fancy equipment and tools professional photographers have, then make use of the "golden hour" which is normally one hour after sunrise and one hour before sunset.

But what if it's cloudy? Then you can photograph during the day but just note that if you photograph a model, that during cloudy days, they will normally have dark shading under their eyes and you will lose a lot of detail, so use a white reflective

surface to help balance out the dark shadows. Perhaps have your model stand next to a light wall. The eyes are the window to one's soul, so it is important that your subject's eyes are always well lit.

## Angle

Have you ever noticed that photographers either bend, stand on their toes, climb up a ladder or tree and even lay on the ground when they photograph a subject? Well, any angle or perspective that you can view your subject from other than the standard human height position is normally quite interesting. People want to see what they normally don't see and that's why an aerial view of a city is normally so fascinating. Apply this rule to your photography as well. Also, by simply lowering your angle, you can get rid of a variety of distracting elements that can be avoided.

So, if you have a relatively standard subject that is not unique, then photography is from a different angle than people normally view it.

In conjunction with the angle, it would be great if you can zoom in on your subject and get rid of a distracting background. I would suggest using your feet and move closer to your subject rather than using the zoom feature on your device as you might lose quality.

## Captivating moment

Captivating moment links to that emotion that gets frozen in time. Now, this step is relatively easy if you photograph an important event like a wedding but combining this with other elements like angle and lighting you can imagine how captivating your image will be.

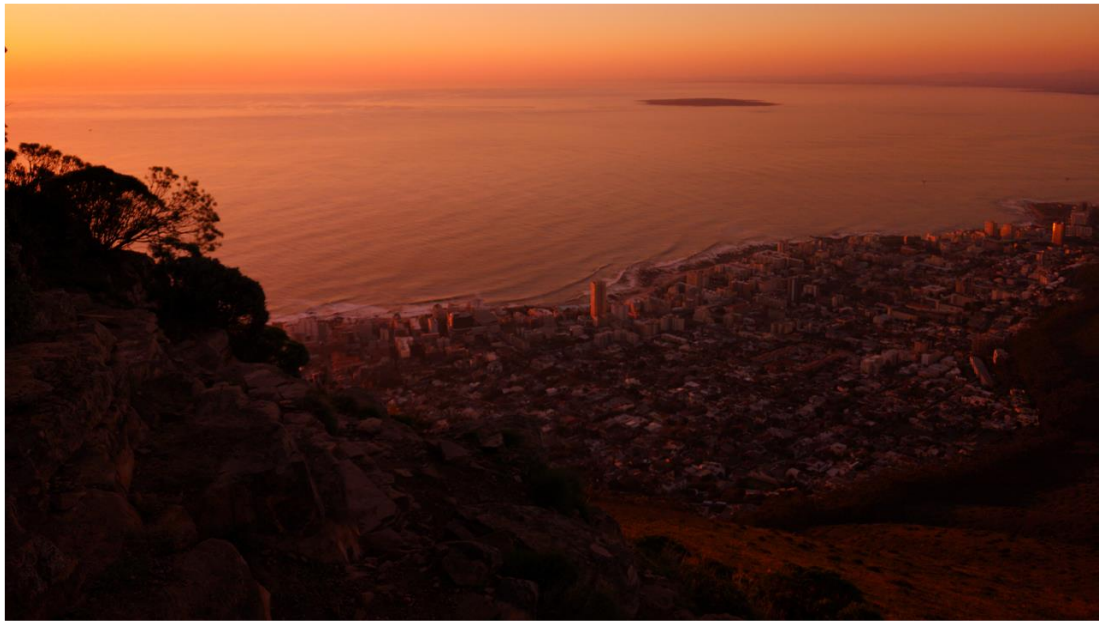
But what do you do if you don't have that captivating moment? Create it with what is around your subject. If your direct surroundings will add to the moment in your photograph, then add it in some way.

This is where it gets tricky. As mentioned, zooming in and removing any unnecessary distractions might seem as though it's contradicting to this point but rather ask yourself how you can add this extra element without jeopardising the quality of your main subject. Perhaps just bring it in vaguely in the foreground or background. Having it blurred out will still place emphasis on your main subject. I would like to show you some photographs I have taken throughout the years and see whether you can identify the 3 factors in them: lighting, angle as well as a captivating moment.

When it comes to photography and graphic design. Designers will mostly use photographs that were taken in a controlled environment, studio or following a brief. Considering the 3 factors discussed, lighting, angle and captivating moment, try and tick all these boxes, whether you are looking for photographs taken by a professional photographer or whether you can take your own photos.

This photograph from a footwear company in South Africa does not focus so much on the shoes per se, but rather the social environment portraying something of the style of the shoes as well. The lighting which is in full shade, provides beautiful textures and colours are not washed out or too dark. The camera angle is slightly lower than the normal human height and takes in quite a lot of the background, that is blurred out to still place emphasis on the subject. The captivating moment is portrayed in telling a story with the photograph – a young, beautiful woman, casually waiting at a bike parking spot, with a coffeeshop in the background creates a sense of relaxation and casualty that fits the style of the shoes.

The second photograph of four violins placed on a textured surface was created using window light from the top left corner. So, by placing the violins on the floor and using the dull coloured floor as a backdrop, immediately places emphasis on the violins. Furthermore, the violins are placed in a diagonal line that creates a dynamic feel. Because there are not a lot of other detail in this photograph, it might be a good image that can be universal – from being used for a classical concert to being used as a background on a music website allows this photo the versatility to be used almost anywhere.



Your thought probably is that these photos were taken with professional equipment, but I would like to show you the last photograph, which I took with my phone.  A city scape from a different view with the golden hour created a warm, dramatic feel.  However, I used my sunglasses as a polarising filter to add the orange tint and make the photo even more striking.  It is possible to use your phone and other equipment in clever ways.

# Magazine cover demo

## Please refer to the recording for the demo

Pretending that you took a photograph that you will be using for your magazine cover today, we will now add this photograph to a magazine cover using your design skills built up during this course so far.

When it comes to photographs used for magazine covers, it will be a good idea to have a focus and some negative space that will be used for your text to be added afterwards.

Our demo will be in Photoshop and entails photo-manipulation using the pen tool, adjustment masks, layer masks, typography as well as layer styles.  We will take stock images in the form of glasses and a face and combine the two images.  If you ever wondered what you would look like with glasses, this technique will teach you how to edit glasses onto a face.  We will then create a magazine cover with our manipulated photograph.

You are more than welcome to use a photograph that you have taken, especially if you have photography skills but if you don’t have a professional looking photograph, then simply refer to the stock websites we have been mentioning during this course.  It is however very crucial that you have a professional looking photograph.  Also, it is a good idea to practice your photography skills as this will allow you to have one of a kind photographs.

The topic for our magazine today is a creative magazine for all design fields.

# Conclusion

The skills that you have learnt up to now should take you quite far, but there is still a lot more to learn.

Recapping on what we did in todays lesson, we looked at the 3 basic factors to consider creating a memorable photograph:  lighting, angle and captivating moment.

We combined two photographs using a variety of photo manipulation techniques.  You can use photographs from stock websites or use your own photographs. We then took our photograph and added it to a magazine cover. This cover will be used in future lessons as part of our magazine that will be created in InDesign, so make sure that you don’t lose it. Eventually all the projects that you create, will account for a portfolio that you can create.